Following the invasion of Manchuria in 1937, the Japanese set about cutting off supplies to the Chinese. In June 1940, Japanese warships moved into French Indochina and closed the railroad at Haiphong. A short time later the Japanese secured British acquiescence to close the Burma Road. The British reopened the Burma Road in October 1940 and for a time it was the only route to supply nationalist Chinese troops fighting the Japanese along the eastern seaboard of China. If the Japanese were to close the Burma Road they would be able to blockade China. Without Allied assistance China's would not have the ability to oppose the IJA.

CONSOLIDATING CONTROL OVER BURMA AND THE CREATION OF THE BURMA AREA ARMY

Following the conquest of Burma, the Japanese spent the next two years familiarizing themselves with the geographic and climatic conditions of Burma. During this period, from late 1942 to early 1943, the Allies mounted two counteroffensives in an attempt dislodge the Japanese from Arakan. The first was an advance into coastal Arakan where the Indian “Eastern Army” led by Major General Wilfred Lloyd planned to reoccupy the Mayu Peninsula and adjacent Akyab Islands, which controlled access to the mouths of the Mayu River and the Kaladan River, the major rivers into the Arakan. Control and possession of the Akyab Islands was strategically important for the defense of Rangoon as well as potentially serving as a gateway for the Japanese to attack India.

Initially, the Allied offensive met with success. The 14th Indian Division quickly occupied the port of Maungdaw and the town of Buthidaung. The village of Indin was quickly occupied. Following their initial success, the Japanese were able to inflict heavy losses on British and Indian troops at Donbaik-Laungchaung on the Mayu Peninsula and at Rathedaung on the eastern bank of the Mayu River. The Japanese began a counteroffensive when reinforcements from central Burma flanked Allied positions by crossing the supposedly impenetrable Mayu mountain range. The Japanese were able to cut off advanced British troops and soon took the village of Indin. The Allies believed the Japanese would then try to capture the Maungdaw-Buthidaung Road. The Allies planned to encircle the Japanese but when a British battalion gave way the Japanese were able to take the